Find Out Where Your Father's Care Is Falling Short Right Now

Four prompts to line up what your father needs against the help that actually shows up, mark what you haven't confirmed, count the work one relative is quietly doing, and decide who to call about each gap.

Where you are

Your father has a care plan on paper, an agency on the calendar, and a sister who covers everything in between. Something isn't getting done, and you can't tell yet whether it's the service, the schedule, or just that nobody has checked.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say which of your father's needs are reliably covered, which ones you have only assumed are covered, and who you need to call to find out.

A one-page list with three headings: Covered and Confirmed, Not Sure Yet, and Nobody Is Covering This, with a name to call next to each item under Not Sure Yet.

Before you start

- Any care plan, agency schedule, or discharge instructions you were given.
- A rough list of what your father needs help with, from your own eyes.
- The names of the people who help him, paid or not. If you have only one of these, start anyway.

PROMPT 1

Line up what's needed against what's scheduled

WHY THIS MATTERS

A care plan tells you what was arranged. It doesn't tell you what happened on Tuesday. Most families read the schedule and assume the visit took place.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your list of what your father needs, and whatever schedule or care plan you were handed.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my father needs help with, and here is the schedule of help he is supposed to be getting:

> [PASTE YOUR LIST OF NEEDS]
>
> [PASTE THE CARE PLAN OR SCHEDULE]
>
> Build a table with four columns: NEED, WHO IS SUPPOSED TO COVER IT, HOW I KNOW IT IS HAPPENING, and SCHEDULED OR SEEN. In the last column, write SEEN only where I've told you I have watched it happen, and SCHEDULED where I'm going on the paperwork. Add a row for every need that has nobody listed against it. Do not rate any agency or caregiver, and do not suggest replacing anyone. Just show me what I've told you.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many rows say SCHEDULED rather than SEEN. Those are the ones you've been taking on faith.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick one SCHEDULED row and be there, or call, the next time that help is due.

PROMPT 2

Separate what's unconfirmed from what's broken

WHY THIS MATTERS

When you're worried, an unanswered question feels like proof. Most of what looks like a failure is really something nobody has checked yet, and the two call for very different phone calls.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The SCHEDULED rows from the first prompt and anything else you're unsure of.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the parts of my father's care I'm not sure about:
>
> [PASTE THE SCHEDULED ROWS AND ANY ITEM YOU'RE UNSURE OF]
>
> For each one, give me three columns: WHAT I'M UNSURE ABOUT, WHO COULD TELL ME, and THE QUESTION TO ASK. Make each question short enough to ask on the phone. Mark every item as UNCONFIRMED, not as a problem. If I've written something that sounds like a complaint, rewrite it as a question I can check. Don't tell me whether the service is working or not; I don't know yet, and that's the point.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Questions you could actually ask a scheduler, a nurse, or your sister without starting a fight.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Make two of those calls this week and write the answers next to the questions.

PROMPT 3

Count the help that isn't on any schedule

WHY THIS MATTERS

The gaps that hurt most are often invisible because one relative fills them without being asked. Her effort hides the gap until the day she can't do it.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes on what the relative who fills in actually does, by day if you can.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My sister [OR WHOEVER FILLS THE GAPS] does a lot for my father that isn't on any schedule. Here's what I know she does:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> List everything she covers, by day of the week and time of day. Then show me what would go undone if she were away for a week, and which of those tasks also appear on the care plan as somebody else's job. Where a task has no one behind it, call it a gap to arrange, not a sign that my father is unsafe. Finish with three questions I should ask her about how she's holding up.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Tasks that appear twice, once on the plan and once in her week. That's a sign the plan isn't being delivered.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show her the list and ask what you missed. She knows more than anyone.

PROMPT 4

Put it on one page

WHY THIS MATTERS

Three lists are easier to act on than a stack of notes. The page you make here is what you'll bring to the next conversation with your father's care team, and it stops you from carrying it all in your head.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've put together about my father's care:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Make one page with three headings: COVERED AND CONFIRMED, NOT SURE YET, and NOBODY IS COVERING THIS. Under NOT SURE YET, put the name of the person or office I should call next to each item. Under NOBODY IS COVERING THIS, state the need plainly, without saying how serious it is or what should be done about it. Leave out medical opinions and leave medication exactly as I described it.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page that a relative who hasn't been involved could read in two minutes and understand.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the page. The next step below starts from it.

See the gaps against the whole picture

Your list shows where today's help doesn't line up with your father's needs, as far as you can see. The care interview asks about every area of his daily life and records who covers each one, so the gaps you find are measured against a complete picture. The result is a Family Care Profile a professional can start from.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›